

Is There Any Concept or Any Idea of Singular Things?

Answered with Regard to
Human Worth and Human Welfare

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Before I proceed to the investigation of the question here proposed, it is necessary to explain its meaning and likewise its importance. By concept I understand, with many recent philosophers, more than the mere representation. The latter may be sensuous, drawn from immediate experience, which comprehends only the surface of things, not what is inward and abiding in them. The objects of concepts are, on the contrary, the essential and unchangeable properties of things; and concepts themselves are either, as genera and species, formed by mere abstraction from experience, or have, through some other activity of the power of thought according to its own laws, acquired a form at once fixed and proper to them. This form consists in this, that concepts, together with a certain matter, exhibit a relation between what is known from experience and something unknown: likeness, for example, a property common to several things otherwise different; cause or force, an inward constitution that contains the ground of what is outward and visible. Ideas, again, represent the highest principles, which may be partly the ultimate end of our actions, partly the most general and first real grounds of the objects themselves. Both are infinite, and therefore attainable only by an unceasing approximation—the one in our theoretical investigations, as we pursue the long series of causes up to its highest member; the other in our actions, which, however excellent they may be, still fall far short of the ideal's perfection.

Both concepts and ideas have this in common, that they contain something abiding

or essential, whereas the representations of the senses inform us only of the changes to which we ourselves, as well as all outward things, are subject. But singular objects are the proper aim of experience, that is, of the senses: what is abiding and general in them the understanding or reason appropriates to itself, and leaves to science to order, to investigate, to work up; what remains it is wont to discard, like a useless shell whose kernel has been picked out.

The singular human being is no exception to this rule. The sciences that make our own species their proper aim—such as anthropology, morals, politics, and legislation—consider only humanity in general, not the human being. The most practical among them make the whole, the general, their end, and set the parts aside, or hold themselves entitled to regard them as mere means to the former. Hence so many thousands are sacrificed for a so-called general good: on no altars does human blood smoke more often than on those consecrated to humanity itself. For singular things, it is thought, are perishable; the species or the genus alone does not perish. The properties by which one individual is distinguished from another are merely empirical; but if they have no unchangeable and essential character, one can form no fixed concept of them. What, then, are they but a kind of mirage or phantasm, pleasant enough perhaps to look upon for a short time? But why spare them, if they stand in the way of any plan for eternity, seeing that they are destined to vanish in the next moment?

Against this it has been said, on the other side, that genus and species nevertheless do not subsist except through singular things, and that the former must therefore perish along with the latter. This answer, which agrees entirely with the opinion adopted by most philosophers, is perhaps less satisfying than it is fit to stop the mouths of those who, without any deeply thought-out theory, would defend the wrong they inflict, under the appearance of the good of the whole, upon so many of their fellow men. To give out the species as a mere concept without a particular object would be the easiest way of settling the matter, if it fitted entirely all the singular appearances one means thereby to explain. To these belongs, first, the striking likeness one cannot avoid noticing between plants and animals of the same species; next, the forces that in all, or in many kinds of beings, always act according to the same laws. For the describers of nature will not admit that their natural species have any other ground than the mind's abstraction; nor, on the supposition that natural forces are merely general concepts, will one be able to understand how the same force—that of attraction and repulsion, for example—can, on the several ways of representing it that have been devised, either be found by a kind of division in many singular things at once, or how of a force that is the same only in respect

of its species there can be as many individual ones as there are substances possessing it. The last seemed to *Aristotle*, among several such examples, so unthinkable that, although he otherwise rejected Plato's opinion concerning the origin of concepts and agreed with the empirical philosophers cited above, he nevertheless assumes a single universally active understanding, which in each human being expresses itself in a particular manner, but is not numerically different. One only fails to grasp how he did not see that the same must then hold just as well of every other force that lies either in human nature or in the nature common to all.

It cannot, consequently, be regarded as so settled a matter that the concepts of the understanding—that of humanity as a whole, for example—can have no real objects outside the individuals themselves. The Platonic Ideas, so far as they are supposed to be forms or patterns after which all that belong to a species are formed like impressions, neither Aristotle, Locke, nor Kant has sufficiently refuted—indeed, has not even expressly contradicted—although they have shown clearly enough the incorrectness of many partly false or distorted interpretations of this theory. In practical life, in the judgments of common human understanding itself, in the plans of legislators and statesmen, the influence of this opinion shows itself even when those who adopt or presuppose it are scarcely conscious of the fact themselves, or have formed any distinct concept of it. If one asks after the objects of these ideas, it does not seem unreasonable either that they may lie buried both in ourselves and in the whole of outward nature, as though beneath a mist or a blinding glare, and that to become distinctly aware of them—not merely to divine them, as most do—a sharper sight is required, which, whether given by nature or acquired by one's own diligence, is nevertheless found in only a few.

But even if this theory, so far as it extends, is correct, might it not nevertheless be far too narrow, and false, if it is moreover exclusive? Are there not likewise both ideas and concepts of singular things, or are those of species and genera alone possible? This question is, especially when applied to human beings, exceedingly important. It amounts, namely, to this: has every human being, just as much as the species itself, a certain fundamental form or essential character that remains the same under all the circumstances of life? Is individuality anything other than a play of changing shapes or new determinations, in which nothing is imperishable except what each has in common with all others, that is, with the general human nature? Or are these changes only successive developments of a kernel which—whether it is just beginning to grow, or has already become a fruit-bearing tree, or after several transformations has become unrecognizable even to itself—nevertheless always retains the original fundamental

features? Is, finally, the goal at which everyone aims, even unconsciously, the pattern after which he must be formed, in truth an infinite idea which, notwithstanding all multiplicity, indeed apparent conflict, has inward unity and unshakable fixity in itself? It is clear that only in this case has every individual an indescribable worth, whereas in the other the species alone has it. That this difference of opinions must necessarily have especially important practical consequences it is almost superfluous to recall.

According to the exposition of ordinary metaphysics, the criterion of singularity consists in a complete determinateness, both in respect of every constitution one can ascribe to things and in respect of time and place. Since both of these are continually changing, it seems to follow that in singular beings, as such, there is nothing unchangeable. But this criterion is also merely logical, and says nothing more than that, in order to distinguish such things from others of the same species, one has no other means than descriptions, because their logical essence itself, which definitions can determine—let alone their metaphysical and real essence—is entirely unknown to us, whereas in the case of general concepts we at least know the first.

The Scholastics come much nearer to the main point, and their disputes over whether the identity of singular things lies in the permanence of matter or of form betray both acuteness and insight. The first is common to many: if the unity of the material were enough, and form were taken into no consideration, then the concept, whose essence is form, could not possibly remain the same. For out of the same piece of wood there may be hewn a block, and the image of a god; form, on the other hand, is on the whole changeable, unless there are certain laws that determine it for every individual and restrict its changeability within such limits that the inwardly forming power can, according to the particular nature or idea of singular beings, develop itself in a constant advance toward greater and greater perfection, while these, on the contrary, in virtue of an organic connection among all that conduces thereto, mutually awaken and help one another.

In Plato's opinion the Ideas were, like patterns from which many copies are taken, general concepts; and the difference of singular things rested likewise not upon the Idea's, but upon matter's greater or lesser aptness to express it. The more recent Platonists were of the same opinion. The Schellingian system, which at bottom is nothing other than the Neoplatonic in a shape altered to suit the present state of the natural sciences, likewise makes it a point of honor to raise itself above singular things as sensuous objects, or wavering images of the Absolute and of the Ideas, that is, of its eternal and unchangeable forms. Individuals ought therefore themselves always to strive to return to the general

nature; and although new ones constantly step forth from it upon the stage, they are nevertheless no longer the same. Particular souls are small parts of the great ocean which, first transformed into vapors or mist—the emblem of the corporeal world—and then into raindrops, gather in springs, brooks, and rivers, in order, after a brief separated existence whose pleasures privation and longing continually embitter, to repent of their defection and become blessed again through forgetfulness.

If this representation is correct, then human life not only has little or no worth, but is even a real evil, from which one must strive to become free the sooner the better. The body, sensuousness, and all that belongs to our individuality is a perishable garment that only hinders the mind's free movements, a weight that presses us down to the earth, or a prison through whose thick walls the reflected light from open nature cannot penetrate. True, we are not permitted to break out; we must remain until we are either acquitted or released. But how much more beneficent, on this presupposition, is the voice of cruelty and bloodthirstiness, which, in leading thousands to the shambles, at the same time opens to them the gates of true freedom, than that of mildness and humanity, which, by crying forgiveness, really imprisons the sinner anew? Could one indeed wish that this theory won general approval, and that rulers and legislators might on that account believe themselves entitled to treat human beings as mere means, to use them as materials for some magnificent work or other that they intended to erect? Is not the concept of right and wrong founded entirely upon personality, i.e. individuality? Abolish this; suppose it could be understood without anything self-subsistent and abiding, that persons were only fleeting shadows that come and pass away—how could any right then belong to them, who in the next moment would have to be lost? How could one punish or reward them, if they themselves vanished together with the action imputed to them? All natural as well as civil laws presuppose something abiding in persons: they would be unfair and unreasonable if the relation among singular beings were not as lasting as it is determinate.

If in this matter one consults experience alone, one receives, as in most cases where general validity is at stake, a quite ambiguous answer. In the whole of inorganic nature there is found none of the so-called singular beings there that possesses any unchangeable character. The species themselves are so wavering that fixed concepts of them are very difficult to obtain. Every inorganic body is an aggregate of many; every part can subsist by itself just as well as in the whole without losing its proper nature. By division the form can also be changed, which is as little essential to them as the matter: who, therefore, can say wherein their individuality consists? When does the river or the building cease

to be the same? The example of Theseus's ship is well known and has often been cited in application to this matter. Even were the fundamental forms of crystals—which in this part of nature nevertheless furnish the best criteria—unchangeable, they are still, like Anaxagoras's homoiomerics, divisible, perhaps to infinity; hence likewise aggregates, not true singular beings. Real individuals we find only in organic nature. The more perfect the organization is, the greater the permanence there is in their form, and the less can any part be dispensed with, or any exchange take place, without essential change in the whole.

Among all figures the circle is the most perfect, because every point in it is entirely determinate, and all of them in the same way by means of the center. There is no difference between singular circles except in magnitude. If we think this last unbounded—which will not do in any other figure, since in these the lines from the center to the extremities are always of unequal magnitude, and consequently not infinite—then of the species itself there can be no more than a single one. All other kinds of curved and rectilinear figures can also be different in other respects, for example in the relation of their ordinates, sides, or angles to one another. Not without reason, therefore, did the ancients represent the highest real principle, the Godhead as the most perfect individuality, under the image of a circle or a sphere.

Nature's whole striving, the general drive to perfection, has no other aim than regularity, and with it likewise permanence in form. Moral as well as physical perfection consists in undisturbed harmony or, in other words, complete individuality, whereby all parts are so connected that none is less essential or necessary than another, and that no contingency has place in it.

The drive to self-preservation is by nature directed most immediately upon the singular, only mediately upon each being's own species. The original desire for activity is indeed by no means merely self-interested, inasmuch as the material it compels us to work upon and to shape according to an idea is not our own nature alone and what belongs to it, or what serves its perfection, but that of other human beings as well—indeed, the whole external world, provided only it is fit to receive such formation, can be its aim. We love beauty, not because it is found in our own person, but also when we become aware of it in any other thing whatever; everywhere, therefore, we seek to realize its idea. Nonetheless the ground of the pleasant impression it makes is that we thereby come to consciousness or self-feeling, i.e. to the sensation of our own power, its increase or strength.

Self-consciousness is the foremost expression of individuality, the highest step known

to us that any finite being has ascended. The more clearly and distinctly we distinguish ourselves from others, and know what marks us off from them, the more perfect we are. All philosophy consists in knowledge of ourselves—not according to the common human nature alone, but especially according to the individual one. The fruit of learning and reflection is chiefly a kind of self-recollection. All development and resolution of concepts, all composition and connection of them, serves only to make consciousness entirely clear, to put us in a position to give ourselves a complete account of ourselves. Conscience and morality rest on nothing else either. To act not from impulse but from principles—is that not to act with distinct consciousness of them? For even in those who are determined by feelings, fundamental principles are at work, though according to obscure and indistinct representations. The whole excellence of our being consists, therefore, in individuality, and the aim of all striving is to attain it in the very highest degree. It is consequently, in the first place, legitimate: it is neither necessary, nor useful, nor possible to suppress it. In the second place, it is the pattern after which everyone must form himself, the idea one ought always to seek to approach; from which it follows that ideas can be individual, and that their objects, just as much as the species, are eternal, infinite, and unchangeable.

One may even raise the question whether there are indeed other ideas of real things than those adduced, and whether the general opinion—that these must either necessarily be general concepts, or that they can at least just as well have species and genera for their objects as singular things—is not founded upon a confusion of the logical and ideal essence of things with the real, which only individuals can actually possess. The dispute as to whether genera and species truly exist outside our thoughts is, as is well known, very old. Those who hold them to be real appeal to the fixed boundaries that nature seems to have set between beings of different species, boundaries that make any transition from the one to the other impossible. As concerns the more perfect organisms in the plant as well as the animal kingdom, the matter is held by most naturalists to be settled; the human race especially is in their view a striking proof of it, since even the lowest among our species is so plainly distinguished from the most excellent among the neighboring species—or, if one will, genera—that no confusion or intermixture seems possible here except through gross ignorance. Nonetheless there are facts and other grounds that might awaken doubt of this. I will not even adduce the many uncertain ones that have been employed here by various famous men, nor the conjectures and hypotheses that have been advanced, but not sufficiently proved, by considerable authors such as Monboddo, Hallen, Lamarck, and even our own Fabricius. In the first place, it is nevertheless certain

that the more general concepts become, and the further they remove themselves from the individual ones, the more their boundaries run together, and the more difficult they become to determine. The criteria of genera are in general more wavering than those of species, and among the former most of all the higher ones—namely, those of orders, families, and classes, of organic as well as inorganic bodies. As our knowledge of nature, even the merely empirical, extends itself, we see gradually vanishing those boundaries which we believed we had determined not arbitrarily, but according to nature's own direction. In the second place, even when not even the longest time seems able to displace them, it is nevertheless doubtful whether this permanence is absolute and essential, or merely relative, since we are compelled to regard as unshakable whatever a few thousand years—to which our experience, when it reaches its utmost, must after all confine itself—have let stand. We find, in the third place, varieties just as well—Negroes, for example, or among dogs pugs and greyhounds—as proper species, which, although they have probably become so divergent through accidental circumstances, have at last taken on an indelible character. How, then, will one make good that the same may not hold equally of the latter?

It is, finally, not so difficult to conceive how species may have come into being through the general laws of attraction and affinity—which in the plant and animal kingdoms acquire several new determinations and a higher significance—even if from the beginning nothing but individuals were brought forth, in many though not yet so distinctly determined gradations and forms of the same force. For since like everywhere seeks like, and since connections, societies, the reproductive drive, and the drive to imitation must always bring several still nearer to one another than they already are by nature, all singular beings must thereby at length have formed groups or clusters, which may indeed at the boundaries stand in a double and ambiguous kinship—namely, both to those within and to those outside the same—but of which the greatest number must nevertheless be recognizably enough separated from those belonging to the surrounding ones. Originally, therefore, there are only individuals; species and genera seem, on the contrary, like societies or works of art, to be of a different and later creation.

Linnaeus, who by a kind of stroke of genius discovered much that in others would have been the fruit of long reflection, held that in the beginning there were only genera, from whose combination the species subsequently arose. Kant's hypothesis concerning the origin of the different human races, the kernel of which is supposed to have lain in the first human pair, has in all likelihood had the same ground in his case, although neither of them has distinctly developed it. I should think that both meant, or at least

ought to have meant, roughly the following by it: neither genera nor species were in the beginning as determinate as they have since become through mixtures and combinations. The forms were at first, as in the works of sculptors, entirely rough. Nature has, so to speak, contented itself with drawing the great outlines; the finer ones, as well as the final polish, have come gradually. It may be conceived, for example, that the first animals existed in a condition in which it might have been difficult to determine whether the form was meant to represent a human being or an irrational animal. After that shape had begun to reveal itself, it might still be uncertain which person in particular it was the master's intention to portray. One does indeed find everywhere physiognomies in which the characteristic and individual seems to be lacking. But the nearer the work came to completion, the more recognizable the distinguishing features became. Here too nature proceeds only gradually. But it is clear that individuality is its utmost aim. As concerns the human race, experience teaches that culture itself contributes to this, and that for that reason one finds among civilized peoples a multiplicity, and likewise a determinateness, in the form of singular persons that is never so great among barbarians and savages. It must consequently be nature's intention to individualize itself: the particular or the individual is not a means and instrument for the general, but the end in itself.

But even if it were settled that individuals are the real—indeed perhaps the only—objects of ideas, has this proposition then any important consequence? Does one thereby obtain a nearer knowledge of individuals, or of the things themselves? Can one now form a distinct concept of it better than otherwise, and determine it so that we are put in a position to distinguish the one from the other? If not, what use can the result be that we have sought so laboriously? For as easy as the empirical criteria of singular things must be to find out—criteria sufficient for use in daily life—so difficult is the fundamental form itself either to fix in the mind or to express in words. Nonetheless there hovers before our eyes from it a clear though confused image: otherwise we should not learn to know things better from acquaintance and intuition than from mere descriptions. The art of painters and sculptors consists in grasping these fundamental forms and in so presenting them that even by beautification they are set in a greater light rather than obscured. Thus it is possible, out of every human face, out of every not entirely perfect character, to form both an ideal and a caricature without effacing the fundamental features or making them less recognizable in the one way than in the other. Neither the roses of youth nor the wrinkles of age alter this form: if only we are properly attentive, we become aware of it in both. Age and culture develop it more and more: in early childhood it is entirely indeterminate; rawness and wildness likewise make it difficult to observe—in

which conditions individuals also seem most to resemble both those reckoned to the same species and those belonging to different ones, human beings and apes, for example.

It makes no difference to the main point that we are not in a position to present this form either in descriptions or in definitions. The first are taken from the sensations of the moment, or from the impressions things make upon our senses, in which the essential and the accidental, the objective and the subjective, are always mixed. For definitions, language lacks the requisite wealth of words, since of necessity it must confine itself to designating general concepts; and although it also has names for singular objects, it has none for the individual constitutions that make them such. The limitation of the human understanding must content itself with knowing things in general and in the large. But one ought not on that account to forget that the general concepts are only aids to survey, not to exact knowledge of things in themselves. For in the real world there are found only individuals, and their essence is not what is expressed by the criteria of the species or the genus, but what lies in the eternal idea, of which innumerable modifications, showing themselves in time, are possible. This idea is not general in the sense that it comprehends several things; but insofar as it expresses all possible states of the same one, one might perhaps give it this name. Properly, however, it is right to make a distinction between this abstract representation of the singular and the concrete one.

It is not my intention to call in doubt the fundamental principles upon which the description of nature builds. I acknowledge, with everyone else, their necessity and their usefulness. But one would, out of love for this science, in my view go too far if one either held the criteria of species to be essential and unchangeable merely for the reason that the limited experience we have does not expressly testify against it, or if in the general consideration one wished to conceal the uncertain, the wavering, the many exceptions and deviations that really have place with respect to the species as well. Even were the opinion of their absolute unchangeability completely proved, it would still not follow that the inward character of individuals is less permanent; on the contrary, analogy, as was remarked above, permits us to infer as follows: just as the criteria of species are less wavering than those of genera and families, so individuals, as the lowest concepts, are subject to still less important deviations from their fundamental form. The proposition I here defend can therefore very well subsist alongside the theory of the describers of nature, although this science cannot make use of it, because the former is both impossible to apply here and, if that could be done, would lead to a prolixity far exceeding the bounds a human science must have. In history, on the other hand, which must necessarily concern itself with singular persons, the proposition here treated

finds both a nearer application and a confirmation—both of them in those delineations of character which history is not in a position to sketch without a deeply searching glance, both into human nature everywhere and into its manifold finer and individual forms, distinguished as these are with the stamp of eternity.

In vain, nevertheless, do I seek by these and several such grounds to convince of the correctness of my opinion those who believe that the gulf between us and the Absolute—which one ought after all to strive to fill—is thereby made still wider and deeper; unless I succeed in showing that this proposition not only can subsist alongside their identity-system, but that this system even necessarily leads to the same result. To that end I shall now explain, as briefly and distinctly as possible, how the relation of individuals to the One and Absolute, as well as to the eternal ideas, seems on these philosophers' own principles best and most easily to admit of being conceived.

In however many ways this doctrinal edifice can be, and actually has been, presented, they all seem to me to agree in the following teachings. The highest real principle cannot be thought otherwise than as pure and unrestricted power, activity, or acting. But since outside itself it finds no material to act upon, and a creation out of nothing is either self-contradictory or at any rate altogether inconceivable, this activity cannot be compared with any other known to us except that of the understanding or of reason, so far as the latter of itself and *a priori* brings forth concepts and ideas. Now the material for these cannot be given from without either; the forming understanding must at the same time be the producing power; but this it can be only through self-intuition—or, in other words: the material for the ideas it cannot take from anything other than itself. Sensuousness one therefore cannot ascribe to the very highest being, because it must always be regarded as passive and a mere capacity for being affected. Hence these philosophers teach that there is an intuition belonging to the understanding, of which I cannot treat in this place. But from this it now follows that the material of all ideas is the same, and that every difference among them rests upon their form—i.e., the many determinations, or properly, boundaries and limitations, that the former can receive. Every idea is nevertheless, like the circle and all other lines or figures, infinite in a certain respect, because, namely, the magnitude is indeterminate notwithstanding the determinate form. They are likewise eternal and necessary: it is the very essence of things that they express. Only when they present themselves in time and space, as the forms of the sensible world, does their eternal nature put on, so to speak, a perishable garment. From their heavenly dwellings they descend into these sublunary regions, where all things are partly changeable and partly show themselves at the lowest step of

their existence, and the ideas in the most degraded shape. The indwelling power seems either, as in the coarser matter, entirely dead, or else finds itself, as in germinating shoots, at the first beginning of its development. This time brings with it, which can be thought neither without changes nor without an orderly succession that must be fixed by a rule. But this succession begins with a point, which is the very least that is real and thinkable; it grows, and becomes at length an infinite line, or, so far as one can represent the point as radiating, into several, indeed innumerable ones. In the same way every force is at the beginning weak and invisible. Life borders upon death before it gathers strength with time. Light and warmth, the most active materials, hide themselves, like smoldering sparks before they are kindled, under the shape of a sluggish matter. But against the unity of form, the unchangeability of the idea, such successive advance is by no means at variance; on the contrary, the rules according to which it develops itself constitute a part of its essence. Furthermore: as many different forms as are possible, so many eternal ideas must there also be; for the understanding intuitively all, its omnipotence can make them all real, and its goodness and wisdom will surely seek to bring the ordinary so-called real things—i.e. those existing in time and space, which are yet properly only weak images of the true ones, namely the objects of the ideas—ever nearer to these patterns.

This whole theory can have no possible application except to individuals. For in the first place, the species is not the pattern after which these must form themselves. Neither is it so determinate that any fixed rule can be derived from it, nor does perfection even belong to its concept; since every singular being, according to the general opinion, which makes the species unchangeable, must necessarily remain within the bounds of the species, however much it may deviate from the rule. Next, not the species alone, but the singular beings too, are different in respect of their form. It is therefore far from the case that the former exhaust all possible forms—which must nevertheless necessarily happen, by virtue of the infinite understanding's richness or fruitfulness.

Without binding myself to the terminology of any author or school, I have sought to present the principles of this doctrinal edifice in such a way as seems to me at once the clearest and likewise the most consistent. That many both so-called Platonists and others who profess it have, in condemning the natural striving that has individual perfection or the preservation of the singular being for its aim, mistaken the spirit of their own system—the reason for this is partly that they have regarded the criteria of individuality one and all as impermanent, without attending to the essential and unchangeable element that contains their inward ground; and into this error they have again been led because

they have not noticed that real individuals are found only in organic nature, but have confused with them the aggregates that make up the inorganic. Partly they have, in order (as they thought) the better to explain the origin of evil, regarded the going-forth of the ideas—i.e. their imaging or development in time and space—as a kind of Fall, which even among the most recent philosophers has given occasion to strange conceptions; although some among them, indeed *Plotinus* himself, have seen that an infinite and constant activity is not possible except through finite products or creatures, that the life of these can be nothing other than an unceasing striving after the better, and that they must consequently all be more or less evil, i.e. imperfect.

Yet this sort of philosopher is perhaps less difficult to convince of this than others. Some among them come to meet us of their own accord in this respect. *Spinoza*, whom despite his very different manner of presentation I do not hesitate to place on the same list, assumes, for example, that every human soul thought under the idea of eternity is imperishable—by which he has meant nothing other than that its essence or fundamental form is through all eternities the same, not that it merely retains the criteria of the species. *Fichte*, whose doctrinal edifice, as his later writings show, comes ever nearer to that Alexandrian and now Germanic Platonism, is likewise not of the opinion that by laying aside one's individuality one would raise oneself to a greater perfection, or to the perfection once unhappily forfeited. Indeed, even according to the principles of the most recent philosophy of nature, the striving to individualize itself is general throughout the whole of nature; and what does this word mean but the assumption of the most determinate and unchangeable form? This drive *Schelling* seems to confuse with a desire for separation, isolation, or independence of the Absolute, with that sinking from the world of Ideas down into the world of the senses which is supposed to be the proper source of all physical degeneration and moral corruption. But singularity does not consist in anything sensuous and changeable; the fundamental form, together with the rules according to which it develops itself in every individual, is an eternal idea. In forming itself after its pattern the soul does not forsake its origin, but much rather returns to it. Let me be excused for using here the turns of speech of mysticism, which for the rest I intend neither to contest nor to defend, since it is only my intention to show that my opinion does not conflict with this school's principles either. That it agrees with a more empirical philosophy—indeed, that one cannot do without it in order to grasp what experience teaches—has already been proved above.

There is, then, a fixed concept of singular things. This concept has objective validity or reality. It stands, therefore, quite otherwise with human souls, and with organic

bodies, which may be regarded as the outwardly intuitable images of the former, than with rough stones or clouds and collections of vapor, of which one can only say in general what they are, but cannot adduce any particular distinguishing mark that may not, while they still exist, be changed into its opposite. Meanwhile one must admit that those objects, just as much as these, seem in the end to vanish. Individuals perish while the species endures. Let them even in the last moment of their existence retain the same essential form as in the first, let the idea live on—the real object is nevertheless no more. The theory is therefore, one might conclude, if not incorrect, at least without use. It is worth the trouble to investigate whether this is so or not.

The ideas that arise in the human understanding, the plans it sketches, have not always any real object. Together with the drawing or the sketch the work itself is not at once finished. The understanding may be fruitful, but the fruits rest, so to speak, in its own lap; outside itself it seems so little able to bring forth anything that not even will and purpose are unfailing consequences of it. In order to realize its idea it needs, as one generally believes, not only other but even foreign forces, which are sometimes difficult enough to move to a cooperation harmonious with it. Even if the work has been well begun, unforeseen obstacles may interrupt it, a hostile force break it down. Defects in the design, which we ourselves discover, may cause us to smash the form in pieces in order to begin anew on a more correct plan. Most human works are houses of cards, which in the heat of the beginning we may indeed have destined for eternal remembrance, but which we ourselves afterwards often seek to eradicate to the last trace. But should the same hold also of the works of nature and of providence, or is precisely the opposite of this correct? Should there ever be lacking here either the means or the ability to carry them out; or should many a building, laid out perhaps on an immature plan, often be destroyed by a more enlightened understanding, in order out of its materials to raise a more perfect one better suited to the purpose? Whether one assumes an inward necessity or an infinite wisdom which, as concerns the arrangement of the whole world, has laid out and carries out everything for the best—the laws of order must be posited as unchangeable, the conflicting forces must at length bring one another into a kind of hovering equilibrium, confusion must resolve itself into harmony, and therein must the general tendency consist. These propositions are indeed grounded upon, or lead at length to, an intellectual system in the whole of nature; nevertheless experience and observations themselves press upon every investigator so irresistible a conviction of their correctness that even those philosophers who have not been ashamed to reckon chance among the operative causes of nature have yet let it act in an entirely regular

manner. A great proof of this is, among others, Democritus's innumerable worlds, in which the same individual beings constantly recur.

The fundamental forms of things are consequently, like the Platonic Ideas, unchangeable—indeed, the only real things; and these are, as I have shown before, not species and genera as objects of the general concepts, at least not those alone, but individuals. That the permanence of species has always belonged, as it were, among the common articles of faith—this has surely had, besides experience, a higher theoretical ground as well in the unchangeability of natural laws, without which an always incomplete induction could yet give no certainty. This ground we now with justice transfer from the species to the individuals. For although experience is so far from confirming it here that the perishing of singular beings seems much rather to testify against it every moment, this appearance really arises only from a misunderstanding, as is clearly recognized when we remain true to the principle. It has been proved that every individual has a fundamental form whose main outlines, under all its alternating states, would be found indelible if our ink were deep enough. These are, namely, visible only in the changeable material that clothes and at the same time obscures them, just as the strokes written with the sympathetic glance become somewhat legible when another substance has given them color; but are they therefore less real, because of themselves they do not strike the eye, or because this cannot happen without the form thereby suffering some change?

Most naturalists have likened the organic material out of which animals and plants are formed in the mother's womb to a germ, or have ascribed to it a kind of preformation, i.e. an inward aptitude for the determinate form, which perhaps only after the lapse of millennia becomes able to develop itself. The organic force is, according to the constitution of the material, different in every body, acting not without rule but according to rules that are for every case determined most exactly; for although outward causes that supervene may alter its direction, they cannot so annihilate its activity that its peculiar tendency does not become recognizable to an attentive eye. No degeneration is so great, no monstrosity even so misshapen, that the original form is entirely perverted. It is remarkable that both the Stoics and other materialists have adopted this preformation system, and yet may nonetheless have believed that at death this form is so broken or crushed that a renewal of it can never again take place. Can it not then, after the dissolution of the coarser body, endure just as well as it knew how, before birth, to keep itself invisibly alive—for how long is uncertain—under so many and such great destructions? For the greatest upheavals in nature leave the proper germs themselves unharmed, indeed sometimes even promote their growth; the finest and often hidden

dissolutions doubtless spare them likewise, or find in these smallest bodies perhaps a resistance corresponding to their fineness and standing in inverse relation to their magnitude. One would much misunderstand me if one believed that by these germs, or by the fundamental form of individuals, I understand anything other than a disposition or a certain determination in the forming power, which is different in every individual. This, I believe, every investigator of nature can very well concede—whether he adopts with Bonnet the evolution-system, or with most of the more recent a kind of epigenesis. For the rest, it would lead me too far if I were here to show in more detail how I represent this matter to myself. The Stoics' *rationes seminales* were likewise only capacities and dispositions toward certain forms, by no means those forms themselves in miniature.

From the standpoint at which we have arrived by these investigations, every human being may be regarded as one of the many possible forms that their common nature or concept can receive. Persons are consequently, in the first place, not insignificant small parts of a whole, but each is this whole itself under his own peculiar form. Next, one ought not to regard individuals as many more or less perfect impressions of the same original, of which each would have to be worth so much the less as the multitude is greater. For when of such a multitude only a single copy remained, little would in a certain respect be lost by the perishing of the rest. But if, on the contrary, individuals do not constitute merely a number in which all units are alike, then their preservation, as concerns their essential form, cannot be less important than that of species and genera. We must consequently suppose that no individual really perishes, but that death is in fact only a transformation, or a preparation for one—whose beginning and progress it is nevertheless as little permitted us to follow with our observations as what takes place with the germ before conception.

If one regards nature merely as a collection of works of art set up for viewing, completeness nevertheless demands that nothing be lacking. Since nature never permits itself any leap, but the series of its products must everywhere be unbroken, just as little can any individual be missing as any genus, species, or variety. But nature is something more than merely such a gallery: it is a perfectly organic whole, for which every one of the self-subsistent parts that compose it has the same necessity or importance as the whole itself, or as all the rest have for the whole. Even the loss of the smallest cannot be made good by any other, because precisely this one's determinate form alone fits into the place where it stands. One can compare with this neither the imperfect works of human beings nor even nature's own, as these present themselves in time or for the moment in experience. In both it does indeed happen that one part can be exchanged for

another without particular loss—indeed, that the work may thereby even be improved; but ideas are, like the ideals of art, imperishable: and although in striving to attain them one is constantly correcting and altering, there is nevertheless, both in respect of the parts and of the whole, something characteristic which furnishes a rule, for every single piece as well as for the species, from which nature itself never dares to deviate.

Aristotle was, as is well known, of the opinion that only the general and the great can be the object of divine providence; that this governs the whole according to certain laws; but that the particular, the singular things, are either far too insignificant to be worthy of this providence, or such hindrances to its great plan that it cannot be carried out without sacrificing them. Without belonging exactly to the school of the Peripatetics, many others have both adopted the same principle in theory and still more often conformed to it in their manner of acting. In statecraft it has always been the great wheel that has determined the machine's course. But since those who direct it regard themselves as the representatives of the species, they find therein a ground for an exception advantageous to themselves. This ground is nevertheless entirely false, since the societies those men represent—as *Pomponatius* has already remarked in his book on incantations—by no means constitute the species itself, but are just as perishable as singular persons, and, so far as they are human institutions, can have no fixed character or true individuality.

One might believe that the opposite opinion, which I have here sought to defend, leads in practice to a still more harmful moral egoism. This consequence would be entirely correct if either the individual could ever perish, or if by a disinterested striving for the perfection of others it were hindered in its own formation. But this is not how the matter stands. The objects of ideas are, like the ideas themselves, eternal; and from morality, which is the general law of reason enjoining inward and outward harmony, both have all their beauty and splendor.

Yet the application of this doctrine in our dealings with our fellows, in public and in private life, I should perhaps have had to add at length in a popular lecture, although it is not difficult to make. But in a learned society, where what is easier ought to be passed over and only the most involved knots, so far as is possible, are to be untied, it is enough to point to the application. A more pragmatic execution, entering into the particular and the concrete, is therefore neither necessary nor, in this place, altogether fitting.